



Photographs by RAVIS SAHNI

INDIA TOMORROW



OVERCOMING COMMUNAL FAULTLINES

# Leaps of FAITH

Forging systematic economic links between poor Hindus and Muslims through urban renewal programmes is the way forward

— By **ASHUTOSH VARSHNEY**

**H**istorically, riots have been the principal expression of India's communal faultlines. Will this continue to be true? In the coming decades, large-scale riots are likely to decline. We know from comparative evidence that as incomes rise above a threshold, the incidence of rioting goes down, though riots do not entirely disappear. India's rapid economic progress, thus, has the potential of dampening old-style communal riots. Moreover, the enormous spread of technology—from TV to the ubiquitous cellphone—is also likely to constrain future rioters. Information technology is beginning to

undermine the freedom to hide in a crowd. Does this mean the end of communal violence? No. The forms of violence are likely to change. The faultlines remain largely unrepaired.

The big issue for the future is how to deal with terror in the name of religion. While the possibility of Hindu terror cannot be ruled out, Jihadi terror is the more serious issue to consider. Such terror has acquired alarming proportions in Pakistan. Its Indian base has thus far been quite small. It may not stay that way however.

Research shows that terrorist networks are normally led by highly educated professionals and intellectuals, but large-scale recruitment takes place only if (a) the government neglects its welfare functions, or (b) economic despair marks a minority community, or (c) a community experiences enduring discrimination or (d) funding